

MINUTES of the Planning Board

May 11, 2026

CALL TO ORDER

Ms. Milikowsky called the meeting to order at 7 PM. Present: Pat Coffey, Jon Zimmerman, Susan Bronstein, Wade Clement, Jennifer Milikowsky (Chair).

PUBLIC HEARING – SPECIAL PERMIT – GROUND MOUNTED SOLAR PV AND BATTERY ENERGY STORAGE SYSTEM

In accordance with Section 5.14.2(b) of the Westhampton Zoning Bylaw, the Planning Board will open a public hearing on Monday, May 11, 2026 at 7:00 PM at the Town Hall, 1 South Road, at the request of Town of Westhampton, owner, to install a medium-scale groundmounted solar array and battery energy storage system at the Westhampton Elementary School. Subject property: 37 Kings Highway, Assessors Parcel #19-52. Application available for public review at the Town Hall, 1 South Road, during regular business hours, or online at WesthamptonMA.gov.

Ms. Milikowsky recused herself, as an abutter to the subject property.

Ms. Bronstein acted as chair pro temp.

The public notice was read.

The public hearing was opened at 7:02 PM.

PRESENTATION

Mr. Stuart Clark, Green Seal environmental, presented the site plan, showing the current layout of the property, and the general layout of the proposed solar PV array.

The locations of the panels, the meter, the proposed Battery Energy Storage System (“BESS”) were noted.

The capacity of the array was noted - 75 kw AC for the BESS, 150kw for the array.

The ground mount array would use helical coil footings, which would result in very minimal disruption to the site; the trenching would need to be backfilled and reseeded.

The specific location of the array and fence were noted in relation to the sidewalk.

The ground-mount array would consist of 184 panels, each rated for 585watt max output. The system – batteries and panels -- would have a nameplate capacity of 107 kW DC, with a AC nameplate capacity of 75kW.

The capacity of the array was noted as about 130% of the current building load, in order to provide for additional future capacity. The town would have the option to ‘bank’ credit for extra generated energy, or to assign them to other buildings or uses (e.g., the Transfer Station).

The BESS is US hardware (from Generac), that is ‘derated’ to 75kwh, which will extend the capacity of the battery to run building systems in case of a grid outage.

There are no issues relative to the existing building transformer, or the grid connection.

The battery will be 278kWh battery, which should power the school at peak demand (40kWh) for slightly more than six hours.

It was noted that the battery could be recharged by the solar PV system, regardless of the grid status. Further, once the battery is depleted, the existing diesel generator would take over.

Ms. Teri Anderson noted that the system was designed to make the school more capable as an emergency shelter – or at least as a warming or cooling center for daytime use in case of extended emergencies.

Mr. Wally Marek, Building Inspector, noted that the Building Inspections team would be looking at the applications.

Ms. Anderson noted that the Fire Chief would be looking at developing an evacuation and emergency management plan that reflects the use – and risks – of the battery.

The location of the battery was noted as being double of what building and electrical code requires, at the request of the Fire Chief.

The location of the fencing around the battery was noted as being ten feet – as required by the Town Bylaw, but double of what is required by NFPA code and building codes. It was noted that the Planning Board could waive that requirement if desired.

The location of an adjacent tree was noted.

There was interest in removing all grass inside the security fence; the applicant agreed that the grass could be removed, and the area laid with stone to reduce maintenance issues.

The matter of decommissioning was discussed, and the need to recycle components as needed. A decommissioning plan was provided, which noted the procedures for facility removal and disposal, and possible recycling of panels and batteries.

It was noted that the structures – the racking, underground conduit and cabling, etc. – could be used beyond the thirty-year lifespan of the panels and battery system.

The advantages of system upgrades in twenty to thirty years were noted.

The battery chemistry was noted, with the chosen batteries – Lithium Iron Phosphate – which were noted as significantly stable and far more stable.

The conduits are not expected to be oversized – adequate for the proposed cable runs; however, the system will be oversized in terms of generation.

Mr. Dan Abrahamson noted that ‘fine tuning’ of the building is ongoing, and a comprehensive building assessment is ongoing.

Public Comment

Ms. Milikowsky (speaking as an abutter) spoke favorably about the proposal.

Ms. Anderson spoke in favor of the project, noting that it would reduce energy costs, and the additional benefit of improving the capacity of the site as an emergency shelter.

Continuance

It was MOVED by Clement, SECONDED by Coffey

To continue the public hearing to Wednesday, May 27, 2026, at 7 PM.

VOTED: 4, 0, 1 (Milikowsky)(7:51 PM).

REVIEW/ACCEPT MINUTES FROM PREVIOUS MEETINGS

No minutes were presented for review.

NEW BUSINESS

May include items not reasonably anticipated 48 hours in advance. Board may discuss new topics raised by individual members, deliberate on potential action or future agenda placement, or give directions to staff.

The board engaged in extensive discussion on recent changes to solar photovoltaic and energy storage laws at the state level, with discussion about the

impacts of the changes to local towns – particularly the impact of accelerated timeline for review and approval at the local level.

Mr. Finn noted that there were draft bylaws and regulations provided by the DOER that could be a starting point for development of a local bylaw.

No actions or votes taken.

ADJOURN

M: Zimmerman 2: Clement

TO ADJOURN.

VOTED: 5, 0, 0. (8:26 PM.)